tors critical for establishing best colleges were meticulously determined and their relative weights finalised. For fair year-on-year comparison, weightages of parameters have been kept unchanged from the past two years.

- Comprehensive objective questionnaires were designed for each of the 14 streams, taking into account these performance indicators, and were put up in public domain—on the websites of INDIA TODAY and MDRA. The MDRA directly contacted about 10,000 colleges fulfilling the eligibility criteria, seeking objective data for verification. Attested soft copies were sought, and 1,973 eligible colleges out of 2,016 participated and were ranked. A few colleges that were not eligible were not ranked.
- After receipt of the objective data from participating colleges, MDRA verified the information provided by them. In case of insufficient/incorrect data, respective colleges were asked to provide complete, correct and updated information.
- Perceptual survey about these colleges was carried out among 1,889 well-informed respondents (608 senior faculty members, 329 recruiters/professionals, 381 career accelerators and 571 final year students) across 27 cities, divided into four zones.

North: Delhi, Noida, Ghaziabad, Gurugram, Faridabad, Lucknow, Kota, Amritsar, Chandigarh, Ludhiana and Jalandhar

East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati, Patna and Raipur

West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad, Indore, Bhopal and Nagpur

South: Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Kochi and Coimbatore

- National and zonal rankings were taken from them in their respective field of experience and given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightages, respectively. Institutes were also rated on a 10-point rating scale on each of the five key parameters.
- While computing objective scores, it was ensured that aggregate data alone was not used and hence data was normalised on the basis of number of students for fair comparison. The total scores arrived from objective and perception survey were added in the ratio of 60:40—for 11 professional courses—while a ratio of 50:50 was taken for academic courses—Arts, Science and Commerce—to get the final combined score.

STREAM	NO. OF PARTICIPATING COLLEGES IN...							
	2026	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019
ARTS	207	196	186	173	172	162	131	121
SCIENCE	239	218	211	198	187	179	145	130
COMMERCE	269	254	229	225	213	202	167	151
MEDICAL	64	54	55	57	53	55	50	50
DENTAL	63	58	62	61	60	59	47	47
ENGINEERING	312	268	284	278	269	249	248	242
ARCHITECTURE	56	54	45	40	42	44	31	31
LAW	77	79	70	72	62	67	49	47
MASS COMMUNICATION	59	60	56	56	47	49	40	39
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	93	82	76	76	71	69	60	51
BBA	240	225	213	201	184	179	147	132
BCA	202	199	169	171	149	146	113	97
SOCIAL WORK	56	54	64	56	56	52	39	36
FASHION DESIGN	79	64	59	51	49	47	35	33
TOTAL	2,016	1,865	1,779	1,715	1,614	1,559	1,302	1,207

Most Improved colleges

- In a significant addition since last year, the India Today-MDRA Best Colleges Survey has begun to rank 'Most Improved Colleges', mapping institutions that have shown the greatest progress over time. This ranking captures the five-year growth trajectory of colleges across all 14 streams by analysing the change in their relative positions in the annual rankings from 2022 to 2026. It focuses on the percentage improvement in rank, thereby offering a dynamic perspective on institutional performance rather than a static snapshot.

The college that records the highest percentage rise in rank over the five-year period is placed at the top of this list, followed by others in decreasing order of improvement. This new category is a testament to the transformative efforts made by educational institutions to enhance their standing and quality and it offers a fresh lens through which aspirants, parents, recruiters and policymakers can assess sustained institutional development.

- An experienced and large team of researchers, statisticians and analysts worked on this project. The MDRA core team, led by executive director Abhishek Agrawal, comprised of senior project director Abnish Jha, deputy research manager Vaibhav Gupta, research executives Robin Singh and Rishav Sharma, and assistant managers EDP Manveer Singh and Mahesh Joshi. ■